decide their vote isn’t necessary? I kept pressure on the staff, telling them to work me hard and add as many appearances to the campaign schedule as they could before election day.

Two days before the election, after getting up in Milwaukee and flying to rallies in Minnesota, Missouri, and Chicago, we arrived in Sacramento for a rally the following day. Nancy and I were put up in a suite at the Red Lion Inn that had a bed on an elevated platform. About 3:30 A.M., Nancy got up to get an extra blanket and took a header off the platform that left her with an egg-size lump on the left side of her head.

In the morning, she could hardly walk and I was very frightened for her, but a doctor who saw her said the injury, while painful, would not leave any lasting damage. Still worried, I resumed the campaign schedule. That day I felt a twinge of nostalgia as I spoke as president before a huge crowd that gathered on the steps of the state capitol—the same place where twice I’d been sworn in as governor.

From there, we flew to Southern California for some final campaigning and then our traditional election-night party at the Jorgensen home to await the voters’ verdict. Nancy was still badly bruised but feeling better.

While we were having dinner, I was called to the telephone. It was Walter Mondale, conceding.

The next day, with Nancy still sore from her fall, we flew to Rancho del Cielo for three days of rides in the morning and cutting and splitting wood from downed oak trees in the afternoons. It was a happy time. I was feeling high after the election; we had taken forty-nine states and fifty-nine percent of the vote, and I saw the election as approval of what I’d been trying to do and a mandate to continue it.

In the rotunda of the Capitol on a very cold day ten weeks later, I pledged to do that. George Bush and I first took our oaths of office, as required by the Constitution, on Sunday,